

the little book of stillness

stop the world for a while

UPPILI RAGHAVACHARI

the little book of stillness
stop the world for a while

Copyright © 2026 Uppili Raghavachari

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without prior written permission of the publisher, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical articles or reviews.

This is a work of nonfiction. Some stories and examples are shared with permission or have been anonymised.

Published by Unrealised Books

A division of Unrealised Limited

Hertfordshire, United Kingdom

First Edition, 2026

ISBN 978-1-9192579-2-1

stoptheworld.app

This book is for general information and reflection only. It is not medical, psychological, or professional advice, and it is not a substitute for the care of a qualified doctor or health professional. The breathing practices described are gentle, but if you are pregnant, or have a heart, respiratory, blood-pressure, seizure, or anxiety condition — or any other health concern — speak to your doctor before beginning. Never force or strain your breath, and stop if you feel unwell, dizzy, or uncomfortable. The author and publisher accept no liability for any loss or harm arising from the use of the practices in this book.

Stop.

The world is increasingly noisy.

Let's stop it for a while.

*Nothing is asked of you here. Nothing to achieve, nothing
to master, nothing to believe. Only the breath you are
already taking.*

O N E

Noise

You don't need to escape it. You need to stop it.

Here is the whole idea of this book, on the first page, so you can decide in thirty seconds whether it's for you.

Most advice about stress tells you to get away. Take a holiday. Unplug. Escape. And escape works — for exactly as long as you're away. The noise waits, patiently, for your return, and it is all still there when you get back, with interest.

This book is about the opposite move. Not escaping the world — *stopping* it. For ninety seconds, or ten minutes, wherever you are standing: the train, the desk, the car outside your own front door. You don't go anywhere. You stop the world, and then you let it turn again — and you re-enter it as someone who knows it can be stopped.

That's the difference, and it's the entire method. Escape removes you from your life. Stopping the world changes your *state* inside it. One is a trip. The other is a tool.

I first developed this in my early years as a coach — simple, physical techniques to quiet a person's internal noise, the brain-noise and stress, for a short while. Long

enough to remember what quiet feels like. Later I built it into an app, so the technique would fit in a pocket. This book is the same thing in words: the one move, and every room you can use it in.

If you have time for a holiday, take one. But you have ninety seconds right now. That's all this asks.

TWO

Cost

What the noise is doing to you

A usual Monday. You wake late, and before your feet touch the floor there is noise all around you — the family, the traffic, the phone already beeping its reminders. Your head is cluttered with yesterday and with what's coming later. Then a train full of commuters, and by the time you reach your desk you're spent, as if you'd already worked a full day — before the day has started.

Overwhelming, yes. But the point worth noticing is that it's *ordinary*. This is simply what a normal morning feels like now.

What actually changed in the last ten years? Attention became a product. Whole industries now exist to fragment your focus into pieces small enough to sell — the interruption *is* the business model. A generation has grown up entirely inside it, minds still forming into their mid-twenties, shaped from the start by the constant pull. It raises the baseline of stress and calls it normal, and normal is the dangerous part: you stop noticing the weight because you've never set it down.

And stress is not a soft problem. Carried long enough it does real damage — to sleep, to judgement, to the body, to how long and how well a life runs. This is precisely the audience that pays the highest price and takes the least time to address it: the ones with the most on their plate, running fastest, least able to afford the ninety seconds, most in need of them.

So, one question. When did you last do nothing?

Not scrolling. Not listening to something on 1.5x. Nothing. Just sitting, letting the mind go where it wanted. The filmmaker David Lynch used to sit and let his dreams surface, and turned them into films. When did you last let your mind simply wander — no screen, no input, no one needing anything?

If you can't remember, you are not broken. You are running the same race as everyone else. This book is about stepping off it, briefly, on purpose.

Pause.

When did you last do nothing?

T H R E E

Source

Where a real version of this comes from

You should be sceptical of a stress technique from a stranger. So let me tell you where mine actually comes from — not to impress you, but because it matters that this isn't invented, and isn't borrowed from a wellness catalogue.

My grandfather was an Ayurvedic doctor.

I never really knew him. He may have been alive when I was very small — I'm not sure. What I know comes from old photographs and from the stories my mother and her brother told. In the photographs he is peaceful. Kind, generous, at ease with people and with the natural world. I can see my mother's face in his.

I regret that I never knew him. But a lineage doesn't require a meeting. His medicine — the food, the remedies, the calm — flowed into my mother, and my mother carried all of it, every day of my childhood, until it drifted into me. Not through lessons. Through absorption. And now that I'm older, and my parents are gone, I find I'm the one passing it on.

So instead of a man I never met, let me tell you about my mother, because she is where the method actually lived.

She rose early — *early to bed, early to rise, makes one healthy, wealthy and wise*, she told me all my life. She prayed first. Then coffee for my father, then the real work: the food. Ayurvedic, South Indian, heavy with turmeric, deeply healthy, and we ate it every day until I left home. When I was sick as a child her cure for a cold was warm milk with turmeric. Years later, at a midsummer retreat in a Swedish forest, they served something they proudly called *golden milk*. It was what my mother gave me when I was four.

She shooed me out of the kitchen — I didn't belong there, she said — but I loved watching her, and the watching was the teaching. She was cheeky about it, too. When I went off to university and tried to cook her dishes, some never came right, and I'd call her: *Mum, I tried it, it doesn't work — why?* And she'd say, sweetly: *Well, if I gave you the whole recipe, why would you ever come home to eat?* So I had to watch her even more closely to catch what she really did. And then, of course, I changed things — fused her food with everything else I was learning, made my

own versions. That is what happens to an inheritance. You receive it, then you make it yours.

But the food was the visible part. The real inheritance was her *state*.

She was a deeply peaceful person — and not because her life was gentle. There was chaos and trouble around us, as there is around most lives. She was calm *in spite of* it. When stress came, she centred herself with Sanskrit prayers, humming them quietly as she worked. That humming was the practice: stillness held against a real, busy, intense life. Not stillness in a quiet room. Stillness in a kitchen, with a family, with everything going on at once.

That's the version that matters to you, the busy one. Not the monk on the mountain with nothing to manage. A working person, fully loaded, staying calm inside the load. That is the whole claim of this book, and she is the proof it's possible.

People lit up when she entered a room. Her small garden overflowed — she talked to her plants and they grew for her; a fig tree, fruits, vegetables. When I moved out I left my Acer in her garden, because things simply did better in her care.

Imagine her garden.

Small. Overflowing.

Tended by a calm hand.

I think all of it — the food, the prayers, the humming, the garden — was one practice wearing different clothes. Wellness wasn't something she *did*. It was something she *was*.

What would she make of an app, her hummed calm turned into something strangers carry in their pockets? I think she'd love it. The music most of all.

I miss her. This book is the recipe she'd have wanted passed on — and this time, I've left nothing out.

FOUR

Mechanism

What the breath actually does — no belief required

Now the part for the sceptic, because you don't have to believe a word of the last chapter for the next part to work on you. This is physiology, not faith.

The practice is Pranayama — an ancient discipline of working with the breath. The word is Sanskrit: *prana*, life force, and *ayama*, to extend or control. It is the fourth of the eight limbs of yoga. At its core it is simple: deliberate, rhythmic breathing to steady the mind and the body. There are many techniques within it — alternate-nostril breathing to calm the nervous system, the bee breath (a slow, humming exhale) to settle an agitated mind, the ocean breath to anchor focus. This book stays with the gentle ones: sit comfortably, ideally not straight after eating, never force or strain the breath. That's nearly all the technique there is.

Here is what physically happens when you slow your exhale.

A long, slow out-breath engages your vagus nerve — the nerve that acts as a brake on your body's stress response.

Pull that brake and several things happen at once. Your heart rate drops, because the vagus nerve releases acetylcholine, which directly tells the heart to slow. Blood pressure eases as the vessel walls relax. Muscles unclench — shoulders, neck, jaw — as the brain signals that it's safe to soften. Studies of slow breathing even show a shift toward the alpha brainwaves linked to calm, focused states, and point to lower cortisol and better heart-rate variability. In plain terms: the body, measurably, standing down from alert.

So the breath is a remote control for your own physiology. It's the one internal system you can take over by hand. When you're stressed, your breath goes short and fast on its own; deliberately slow it, and the signal runs the other way — you tell the brain you're safe, and the body obeys.

Try it now. In for four seconds. Out for eight. An exhale twice as long as the inhale. A few rounds and you'll feel the brake engage — at your desk, in this chair, reading this.

Breathe slow.

In for four. Out for eight.

A few rounds. Then read on.

Why the breath, and not some other anchor? Because it's biologically tied to *now*. You can worry about tomorrow and replay yesterday, but you cannot breathe in the past or the future. Every breath happens right now. And now. And now. Returning your attention to it breaks the overthinking loop, because the breath only exists in the one place your anxious thoughts never go: the present. And it's always with you — no equipment, no notebook, no app required. (The app is useful; it prompts you, holds the rhythm, gives you the music. But the breath is the instrument. The app is only the music stand.)

One last distinction, for anyone who tried meditation once and decided they were bad at it. This is not that. No emptying the mind — your brain keeps a job, counting and holding the pattern. No sitting for an hour — a single minute changes your state. No belief. Change the length and speed of the breath and the body reacts, whatever you do or don't think about it.

And one honest line, because this book won't overpromise: breathwork is not a cure, it is not enlightenment, and it is never a substitute for a doctor. It is a tool for changing your state — nothing more. That turns out to be quite a lot.

FIVE

Stillness

The first stillness

Here is the whole practice, as it lives in the app — and as it lives with no app at all.

You tap once. The world begins to stop.

First, the breath. Box breathing — the square. In for four. Hold for four. Out for four. Hold, empty, for four. Repeat. Four equal sides, like breathing around the edge of a square. It's the simplest pattern there is, and it's trusted in the hardest circumstances there are — special forces use it to steady themselves before the worst moments of their work. If it can hold a person there, it can hold you between two meetings.

This is the atomic unit of everything in this book. Learn this one square and you have the whole method; every practice that follows is just this, in a different room.

Then the music. An original sitar score, made for exactly this — ten minutes of sound to be still inside. The breath opens the door; the music holds it open.

And at the end, three words: *the world returns*. Because it does. The noise, the inbox, the day — all of it comes back. But you come back to it changed.

There are two ways to practise, and both are correct. **Eyes open:** watch the orb; it breathes, you breathe with it. **Eyes closed, phone in pocket:** learn the square — four in, four hold, four out, four hold — then put the phone away and let the music guide you. That second way is the commuter's way, and probably yours.

You have permission to do whatever you like with this. That's the standing rule of the whole book. And you can do it with no app at all: a chair, ten unhurried minutes, the square, and whatever quiet you can find. Everything here works offline, because the practice was never in the phone. It was always in you.

Close the book.

Close your eyes.



Breathe the square.

In, hold, out, hold. Four each.



Come back when you're ready.

SIX

Rooms

Small stillnesses — the one move, in the rooms of your day

The ten-minute session is the anchor. These five are the small stillnesses you fit into the corners of an ordinary day. Each is the same square breath — the same one move — carried into a different room. One to three minutes. Nothing required but you.

The waking breath. Before the phone. That's the discipline — the first minutes of the day are yours, not the notifications'. Still in bed or on its edge: in for four, out for eight, ten slow rounds. You're choosing the state you begin from, instead of letting the phone choose it. In time, the reach for the phone weakens. The morning comes back to you.

The commute breath. Standing on the train, phone in pocket, the heat and squash and noise all around. Earphones in or not, eyes open or closed: breathe the square. The carriage doesn't change. Your position inside it does. In time, the commute stops being lost time and becomes the most reliable stillness of your day.

The desk breath. The ninety seconds between meetings — the gap everyone spends refreshing email. Sit back from the screen. In for four, out for eight, six rounds, shoulders down on every exhale. This is the one for the operator who “doesn’t have time”: ninety seconds exists in every calendar ever built. In time, you stop carrying each meeting into the next.

The doorway breath. The transition home. You’re carrying the residue of the whole day, and the people behind that door deserve better than the residue. So pause before you enter — at the door, or in the car. Five slow breaths, out longer than in, and leave the day where it belongs: outside. In time, you arrive home as a person, not as what the day made of you.

The night breath. Last thing, in the dark. Not a sleep cure — a way to stop carrying the day into the night. In for four, out for eight, and with each exhale let one piece of the day go. You’re not solving anything at this hour. You’re setting it down until morning. In time, the mind learns the day is allowed to end.

*Which room
do you need most today?*

S E V E N

Return

When the mind won't stop

Here is what will happen the first few times: your mind will race. You'll sit to be still and your head will fill with everything except stillness.

I know, because it happens to me — times the mind wouldn't slow and the breathing didn't seem to help at all. So hear this before you conclude you're bad at it: the racing is not failure. It's simply what minds do, and everyone's does it.

This is a practice. You get better at it. And you get better not by forcing the mind quiet, but by *returning*. You drift, you notice, you come back to the breath. That noticing IS the practice working. The repetition is the return, not the stillness. Come back, and come back again, and the quiet grows on its own schedule.

My mother had her own version of this. When I was with her and my attention wandered off, she'd pull me up on it — *don't do that; you're practising something, and what you're practising isn't good for you, or for anyone you're talking to*. She understood the thing most people never say out loud: wherever your attention goes, you're training it to

go there again. Drifting is practice too. So when you catch yourself gone — in a conversation, in a breath, anywhere — the move is always the same. Come back. That's the entire art.

And one thing that matters, especially for a high-performer wired to keep streaks: there is a difference between a ritual and a streak. A ritual is something you return to. A streak is something you can break — and breaking it becomes the excuse to quit. So let me be plain: missing a day is fine. Missing a week is fine. There is no chain to protect, no score, nothing to lose.

Nothing is asked of you. Stop the world when you want to. It will be there when you return. It always is.

E I G H T

Weight

The heavy days

Some days are heavier.

A partner lost. A marriage ending. A company failing. Days of dread, days of grief — days the breath cannot fix.

I want to be honest about those days, because this book has no business overpromising, least of all here. We invite calm in. We never claim calm will fix your pain. Ten minutes of breath does not resolve grief, and was never meant to. What it can offer someone carrying real weight is smaller, and still real: a moment of stillness *inside* the weight. A pause, not a solution. Somewhere to stand while the hard thing is happening.

I know this from the inside. Stillness has carried me through some very hard times, recently. It didn't fix them. It gave me a floor to stand on while they ran their course.

On the worst days, you have permission not to practise at all. Even the invitation is optional here.

And one thing said plainly, because it belongs in any honest book about hard days: some weights need more than a breath. A friend. A professional. There are people

and organisations whose entire purpose is to help carry the heaviest things — and reaching for them is not a failure of stillness or of strength. Reaching out *is* strength. Do not face the heaviest things alone.

The breath will still be here when you're ready. It is very patient.

If you are struggling, please reach out. In the UK, the Samaritans can be called free, at any hour, on **116 123**, or emailed at **jo@samaritans.org**. Your doctor is also there for this, not only for the body. Wherever you are, a trusted person or a professional is a strength worth reaching for — never a weakness.

N I N E

Carry

Carrying it

What happens after weeks of this?

Small things, mostly — which is to say, real ones.

The commute changes first. Have you had time simply disappear — forty minutes folding into what feels like five? That starts to happen. The gap between meetings stops being a scramble and becomes a breath. The pause before you answer the difficult email gets a fraction longer, and the answer gets better. Nothing announces itself. You just notice, one day, that the noise is the same and you are different inside it.

And somewhere along the way it stops being sessions and becomes a way of moving through the world.

My mother, one last time — because she's the proof of where the road goes. Her stillness wasn't something she did at set hours. It was in the humming while she cooked, the notes she made about her plants, the way a small garden overflowed for her, the way rooms changed when she walked in. Stillness wasn't something she did. It was something she was. That's the far end of this practice.

None of us gets there fast, and it doesn't matter. The direction is the point.

I have my own small version now. I walk the lake where I live and sit under a weeping willow, watching the birds move slowly across the water, and I pause, and let time go quiet. Find your willow — whatever, and wherever, it is.

Where is your willow?

T E N

Deeper

If you want to go further

Everything before this page is complete. You could close the book now with the whole method in hand, and I'd be glad.

But if the practice has taken hold, and you want to go one step deeper, there is a longer guided stillness I've recorded in my own voice — a slower, quieter practice that goes a little further than the square breath. It's optional, it asks nothing, and it lives with the app so you can be led through it rather than reading it. When you're ready — not before — it's there.

And there is a slow, quiet path forming beyond this book — deeper sessions, gatherings, a growing world of practice, built slowly and without hurry. If you'd like to walk it, leave your email in the app and we'll keep a place for you as it grows. Nothing more is asked. There is never a rush here.

Things you might notice
when you finally stop

The sound of your own breathing.

Birds you'd stopped hearing.

The tension you were holding in your shoulders.

The warmth of light on your skin.

The quiet between two thoughts.

That you'd been rushing for no reason.

*That today, without doing one more thing,
you are already enough.*

So, in my mother's spirit, and my grandfather's —
pause, and reflect on your world, from time to time.

Do not be afraid of the silence.

You may find the answers you're looking for
in those small moments
of stillness.

Stop.

Breathe.

Welcome back.

stoptheworld.app — no download. just breathe.